

Cardiff Community Meals

Platform Plan — donation-funded meals for Cardiff residents who are ill, disabled, or recently discharged from hospital

Working name — rename freely. Prepared for Sarah • 4 August 2026

1. Overview

Cardiff Community Meals connects three groups: neighbours who need a hot meal while they recover from illness, disability, or a hospital stay; community members who want to fund or dedicate a meal; and local Cardiff food businesses who cook and deliver it. The site sits between a request/referral system, a donation platform, and a lightweight logistics tracker.

The model mirrors two things that already work in Cardiff: Cardiff Council's Meals on Wheels service (self- or family-referral, ~2,000 meals/week, welfare check included) and UK food-referral platforms such as Food Aid Referral, which manage vouchers between referrers, providers, and recipients. This project adds a public donation and business-showcase layer on top of that referral model.

2. Who it's for

Recipients

- Elderly or disabled residents living independently in Cardiff
- People recently discharged from University Hospital of Wales or another Cardiff hospital
- Anyone in a temporary period of ill health with no one to cook for them

Referrers

- The person themselves (self-referral)
- Family, friends, or neighbours
- Social workers, GP surgeries, hospital discharge teams, community wardens

Donors

- Local residents funding a one-off or recurring meal
- Groups/workplaces sponsoring a week of meals for someone

Business partners

- Cardiff cafés, restaurants, and caterers who cook and/or deliver meals, in exchange for public recognition and local goodwill

3. User roles & permissions

Role	Can do	Requires
Visitor	Browse businesses, impact stats, how-it-works	No account
Donor	Browse open requests, donate, book a specific meal/business, leave a message	Email + payment
Requester / Referrer	Submit a request, edit it, see status, add delivery notes	Verified phone/email; ID check if referring a third party
Business partner	Manage profile, accept/decline bookings, mark meals prepared/delivered, view fulfilment history	Approved application + valid FSA food hygiene rating
Admin / moderator	Verify requests, approve businesses, resolve disputes, view all data, export reports	Staff/trustee account

4. Site map

- Home — mission, live impact snapshot, primary CTAs (Request Help / Donate a Meal / Partner With Us)
- Request Help — referral form (self or on behalf of someone)
- Donate & Book a Meal — browse verified open requests, choose amount/meal, pick or auto-match a business
- Our Business Partners — showcase grid: logo, cuisine, meals delivered, rating, "Book from them" link
- Impact Dashboard — meals delivered, £ raised, requests fulfilled, top partners, coverage map of Cardiff postcodes served
- How It Works / About — process explanation, safeguarding statement, FAQs, contact
- Partner Sign-Up — business application form
- Account areas — Requester dashboard, Donor history, Business portal, Admin console (not in the public prototype)

5. Core user flows

A. Request or referral

1. Referrer completes the Request Help form: recipient details, situation (illness / disability / hospital discharge / other), dietary needs and allergies, delivery address and access notes, urgency, and referrer's relationship to the recipient.
2. Consent is captured for the recipient's data being shared with a business partner for delivery.
3. Admin reviews and verifies the request (see Section 6) before it becomes publicly visible — this step exists specifically to protect vulnerable people from being listed without consent or being targeted by bad actors.
4. Once approved, the request appears on the Donate & Book a Meal page as an anonymised card (first name + area only).
5. Requester/referrer can track status: Pending review → Open for donations → Meal booked → Prepared → Delivered → Complete, and can add more requests if needs continue.

B. Donate & book

6. Donor browses open requests or goes straight to a favourite business.
7. Donor selects a request, chooses a meal value or a set number of meals (e.g. 1 meal, 5 meals, a week of meals), and picks a partner business (or "let the platform match one nearby").
8. Donor pays online; funds are held until the meal is confirmed delivered, then released to the business.
9. Donor optionally leaves a short message of encouragement, delivered anonymously with the meal.
10. Donor receives a confirmation and, later, a delivery confirmation — closing the loop.

C. Business fulfilment

11. Business receives a booking notification with delivery window, address, dietary needs — no donor payment details.
12. Business accepts, cooks, and marks the meal Prepared, then Delivered (with optional photo/timestamp) or logs an issue.
13. Completed bookings add to the business's public meals-delivered count and feed the impact dashboard.

6. Trust, safeguarding & verification

Because recipients are, by definition, vulnerable, verification is the most important workflow on the site, not an afterthought.

- Every request is reviewed by an admin/trustee before it goes public — no unmoderated listing of vulnerable people.
- Third-party referrals (not self-submitted) require a callback or confirmation from the recipient, or referral from a recognised source (GP, hospital discharge team, social worker, Age Connects Cardiff & Vale) before approval.
- Public request cards never show a full name, exact address, or contact details — only first name/initial and general area (e.g. "Margaret, Cathays").
- Business partners must hold a valid Food Standards Agency hygiene rating (verified at sign-up and re-checked periodically) and, if collecting/delivering to a private address, at least one DBS-checked point of contact.

- Data handling follows UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018; a data retention and safeguarding policy should be published on the site.
- Wales-specific: as a public-facing Cardiff service, consider Welsh Language Standards — bilingual English/Cymraeg pages for core flows (Request Help, Donate, How It Works) are recommended, and are common practice for Cardiff-based charities.
- A clear escalation path exists for admins if a delivery reveals a safeguarding concern (e.g. signs of neglect) — a documented referral to Cardiff Council Adult Services.

7. Business partner programme

Local Cardiff cafés, restaurants, and caterers apply through the Partner Sign-Up page: business details, cuisine type, food hygiene rating, delivery capability (own drivers, courier partner, or collection only), and typical capacity.

- Approved partners get a public profile on Our Business Partners: logo, story, cuisine, meals delivered to date, and a "Book from them" shortcut on the donation page.
- Recognition tiers (e.g. Bronze/Silver/Gold Community Kitchen) based on meals delivered, displayed as a badge — free marketing in exchange for discounted or in-kind meals.
- Businesses can optionally donate meals outright (no donor payment) to build goodwill and badge status faster.

8. Donations & meal booking

Cardiff Council's own Meals on Wheels currently charges around £6.01 per main meal; that is a reasonable public benchmark. Suggested donation tiers:

- £7 — one meal
- £35 — five meals (a working week)
- £70 — two weeks of meals
- Custom amount, or "cover a whole request"

Payments should run through a UK-compliant processor (Stripe is the standard choice) with funds held in escrow-style until delivery is confirmed, protecting both donor and business.

9. Impact dashboard

A public page builds trust and encourages repeat donation and business sign-ups:

- Total meals delivered, total £ donated, number of people helped, all-time and this-month
- Requests currently open for donation vs fulfilled
- Leaderboard of top contributing businesses and top donor postcodes/areas
- A simple map or list of Cardiff areas served (Cathays, Riverside, Grangetown, Splott, etc.)

10. Data model (core entities)

Entity	Key fields
User	id, name, email, phone, role (donor/requester/business/admin), verified flag
Request	id, recipient first name, area, situation type, dietary needs, urgency, status, referrer id, consent flag, verified_by (admin id), created_at
Business	id, name, cuisine, hygiene rating, delivery type, meals delivered count, badge tier, approved flag
Booking / Donation	id, request id, donor id, business id, meal count, amount, message, status (pending/prepared/delivered), payment id
Delivery log	booking id, timestamps for each status change, delivery confirmation, issue notes

11. Recommended tech stack for a production build

The attached prototype is static HTML/CSS/JS with browser-local storage standing in for a database, so it can be opened directly in a browser with no setup. For a real, publicly deployed version, recommended:

- Frontend: same HTML/CSS/JS approach, or React/Next.js if the team wants richer interactivity later
- Backend/API: Node.js (Express) or Django — either is fine for this scale
- Database: PostgreSQL
- Payments: Stripe (Connect, so funds can route to business partners)
- Auth: email/password + magic link, with phone verification for requesters
- Hosting: any UK/EU-region host to simplify GDPR data residency (e.g. EU-region on Render, Fly.io, or AWS eu-west-2 London)
- Notifications: email (Postmark/SendGrid) and SMS (Twilio) for delivery confirmations and admin alerts

12. Legal & compliance notes

- Register with the Fundraising Regulator if collecting public donations at scale, and consider Charity Commission registration if operating as a charity rather than a CIC/community group
- UK GDPR / Data Protection Act 2018 compliance for all personal and health-adjacent data (situation/illness details count as special category data — extra care required)
- Terms of Service and a public Safeguarding Policy, linked from every request/referral form
- Food handling: partner businesses must meet Food Standards Agency requirements; the platform itself does not handle food
- Consider Welsh Language Standards compliance for a Cardiff public-facing service

13. Suggested roadmap

14. Phase 0 (now): working prototype — demonstrate the flows to stakeholders and potential partners (this deliverable).
15. Phase 1: pilot with 2–3 Cardiff cafés/restaurants and referrals from one partner organisation (e.g. Age Connects Cardiff & Vale), manual admin verification.
16. Phase 2: real backend, Stripe payments, automated notifications, 10–15 business partners, self-serve business sign-up.
17. Phase 3: scale across Cardiff neighbourhoods, bilingual site, integrate with Cardiff Council/NHS discharge referral pathways.

14. About the accompanying prototype

A working front-end prototype is included alongside this document: plain HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, no build tools required. It uses the browser's local storage as a stand-in database so you can submit a request, make a donation/booking, and watch the impact dashboard and business showcase update live. It implements the flows in Section 5 for demonstration purposes; it is not connected to real payments or a real database, which is expected for Phase 0.